



National SEND Audit 2023 - Phase 1 **REPORT**

This is a top-level summary of some of the key findings from the National SEND Audit that took place between 15/09/2023 and 15/10/2023.

A more detail report is currently being compiled to be sent to policy makers including The Education Select Committee.

By Dr Anita Devi, October 2023

Context & rationale

Working in partnership, School Improvement Partners and Dr Anita Devi of TeamADL constructed a 7-section SEND Audit for schools, colleges and alternative provision providers.

The seven sections in order were:

1. Quality of Provision for All
2. Reasonable adjustments
3. Identification and additional provision
4. Leadership and team working
5. Co-production
6. External stakeholders
7. Impact

These sections corresponded to four core themes:

1. Inclusive and responsive provision in place
2. In-house processes, systems and structures
3. Relationships and collaboration between all
4. The difference themes 1-3 were having on outcomes for children and young people

Under each section, 10 statements were provided for senior leaders and those who lead on SEND to rate their current position based on the colour code:

- Red - not evident
- Amber - developing
- Green - secure

Many of the statements that specifically related to statutory requirements were marked (S). On completion, individual settings received a bespoke report of findings pertaining to their own scores and this also included recommendations for further growth. In effect, the audit recorded live data, as to where the setting was at this point in time.

This year marks 9 years since the passing of The Children and Families Act 2014. The system is far from fit-for-purpose. In December 2022, The House of Lords (whilst reviewing implementation of The Children and Families Act 2014) reported, that there had been 'inadequate implementation' in terms of monitoring and many 'missed opportunities' to improving the lives of children and young people.

Before the decade mark in 2024, we wanted to spotlight key issues and see if there was a different and better way of working. We discovered both.

In this top-level report, we share with settings that took part in the National SEND Audit 2023, aggregate scores of the 7 seven sections plus growth points for us as co-constructors of the tool. A more detail report with poignant recommendations is being produced and will be sent to policy makers for consideration, as we move towards the decade milestone.

The following information was provided to all those choosing to engage

<https://sis-catalyst.webflow.io/campaigns/national-send-audit>

Breadth of engagement

The National SEND Audit was open for 30 days. This was approximately two weeks in to the new academic year and at a time when several other organisations and localities were undertaking surveys / opinion polls related to SEND.



Growth point: Further consideration needs to be given to the timing of such an audit to maximise participation.

Total engagement included 197 settings. These were sourced through volunteer sampling. In other words, a non-probability sampling technique in which participants self-select or volunteer themselves to participate in a study. The data set also included volunteer sampling through senior school / MAT leadership (i.e., Multi-Academy Trust (MAT) Leaders supporting full participation from their education community), as well as wider sector advocacy (i.e., key individuals and organisations publicly promoting and sharing the audit with others). Participation was primarily sought in two ways, through various social media platforms and targeted emails to individuals and key organisations.

What is most encouraging is this represented both a wide geographical range and broader sector involvement. This is reflected in the three graphics below:

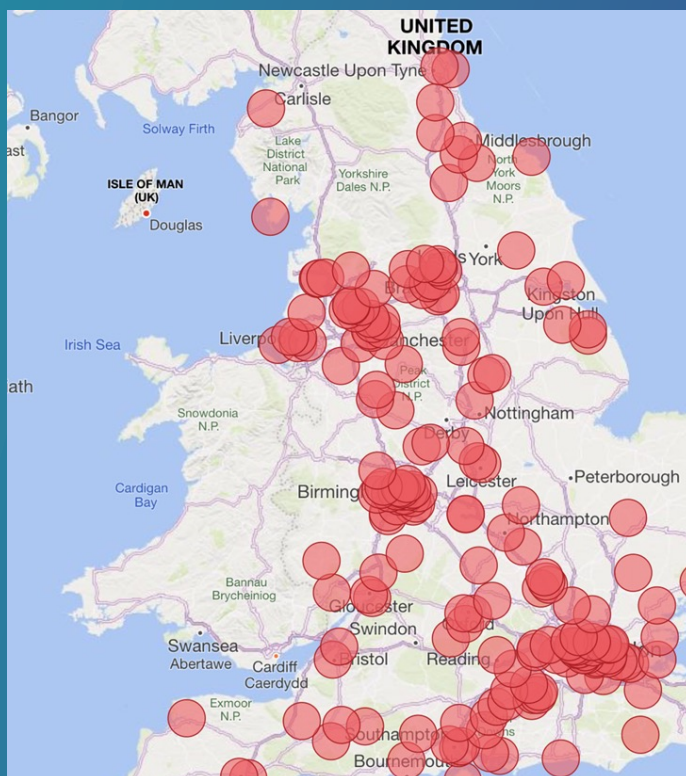


Figure 1: Geographical spread of all the settings who participated. The relevance of this will be elaborated upon in the main report.

National SEND Audit 2023 - Phase 1

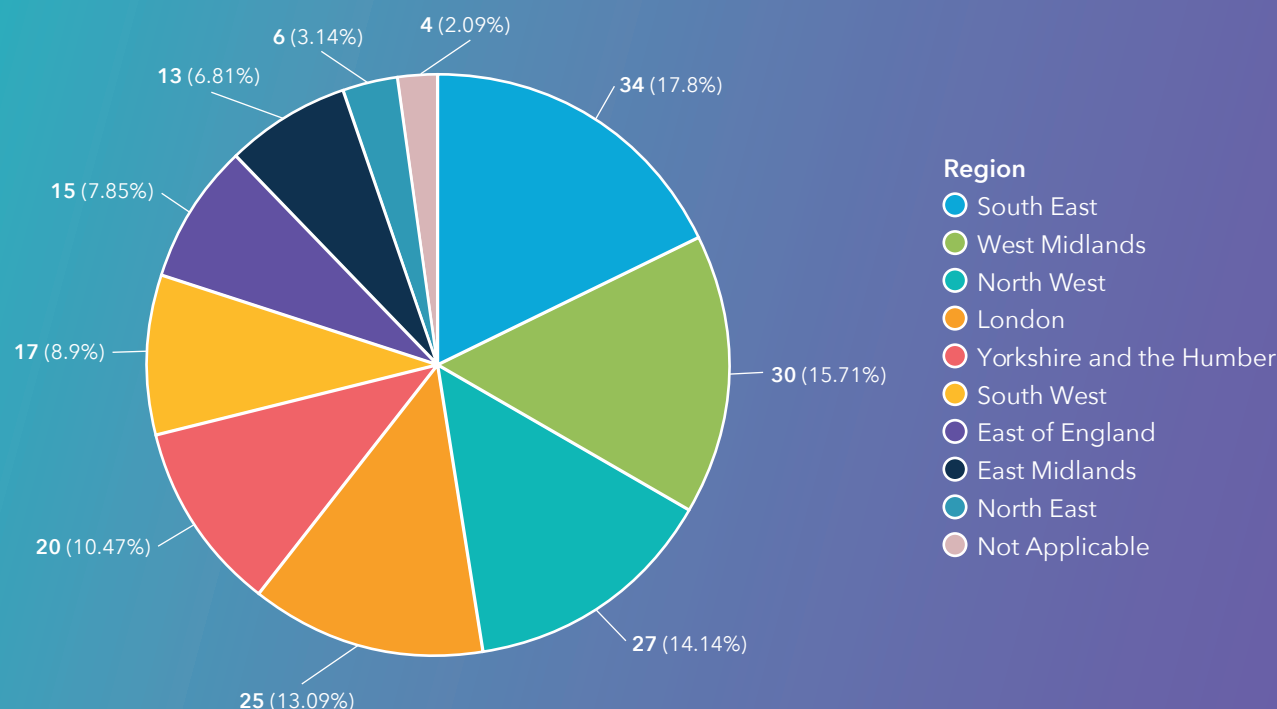


Figure 2: Regional spread of participating settings in National SEND Audit 2023

As to be expected, the majority of schools participating were primary schools. The least were those who deliver Post 16. The majority of settings involved were those who were graded 'Good' during their last Ofsted Inspection (75.2%). The remaining were either 'Requires Improvement' or unclassified. A small proportion were from the population previously rated as 'Inadequate'.



Growth point: It would be useful to review the language of the landing page in terms of being Post 16 relevant and highlighting the evidence-based approach of the audit to Ofsted Inspections.

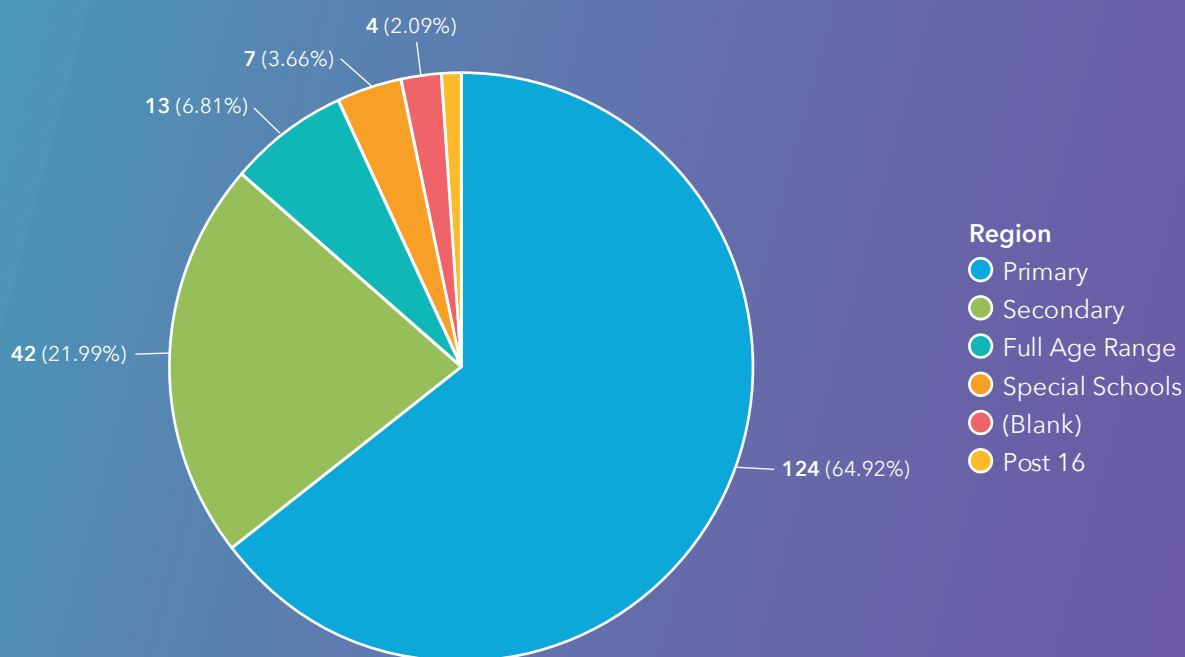


Figure 3: Type of setting engaging in the National SEND Audit 2023

We received a range of anecdotal comments by those involved from the trial over the summer to actual delivery in Autumn Term (1) 2023. The most notable was from a governor:

***“ There was some interesting parts about accessibility audits on here - something that’s widely overlooked.*”**

The comment is relevant in highlighting not only the complexity of SEND, but also how some aspects can slip through the cracks, if not diligently monitored. Given the interconnectivity of the SEND system from inclusive practice to assessment, identification, additional provision and impact, a single lapse locally, regionally or nationally could result in significant negative impact for individual children and families and/or the wider system.

The next section deconstructs the findings in more detail.

Data analysis

The aggregate data across all settings seemed to show just over half were secure in all 7 aspects reviewed in this audit. However a significant proportion were developing many aspects and a marginal proportion had areas that were not secure.

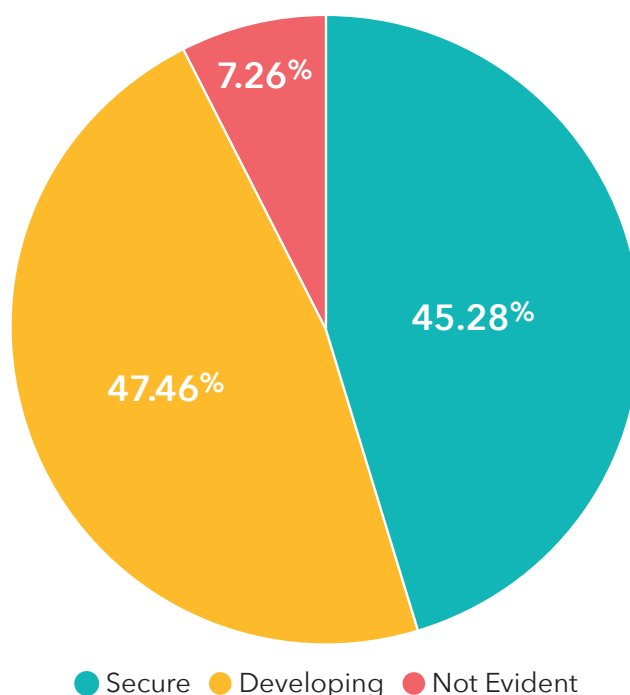
Given that next year marks the 10th year of enacting the Children & Families Act 2014, the expectation would be for these figures to be higher, especially since significant investment has been made in this area. A Department of Education (DfE) press release in August 2023, suggests a 60% increase in high needs funding since 2019-20 bringing the yearly total in 2024-25 to £10.5 billion. This figure does not include additional funding given to commissioned delivery partners responsible for messaging, training and transformative work. A previous Freedom of Information request highlights these to be over £150 million. This level of investment would warrant a higher percentage of settings to be secure in delivering SEND Provision. Admittedly a larger sample could shift the figure, however the data does reflect a national spread.



The breakdown of each dimension provides further insights.

Area 1: Quality of Provision for All

Average Score: 1.38 (69.0%)



Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

The scores varied in this domain compared to the overall data overview. With the majority skewed towards developing. The weakest areas were seen in the use of multi-sensory resources, alternative methods of records and tools to support logical inquiry across the curriculum.

The data also revealed that most settings have pockets of good practice, but consistency across schools is a major challenge. This was the same for primary and secondary, but more evident in secondary.

Implications for the child and young person and their families:

- At primary level, good practice in meeting needs in the classroom isn't just about the lottery postcode. A secondary factor would be the practitioner in the classroom.
- At secondary level, a young person with needs is expected to adapt their approach to different teachers and subjects. This adds an additional level of difficulty to their learning.

There are strategic tools to address consistency of provision across the school and these were mentioned in the recommendations of the audit.

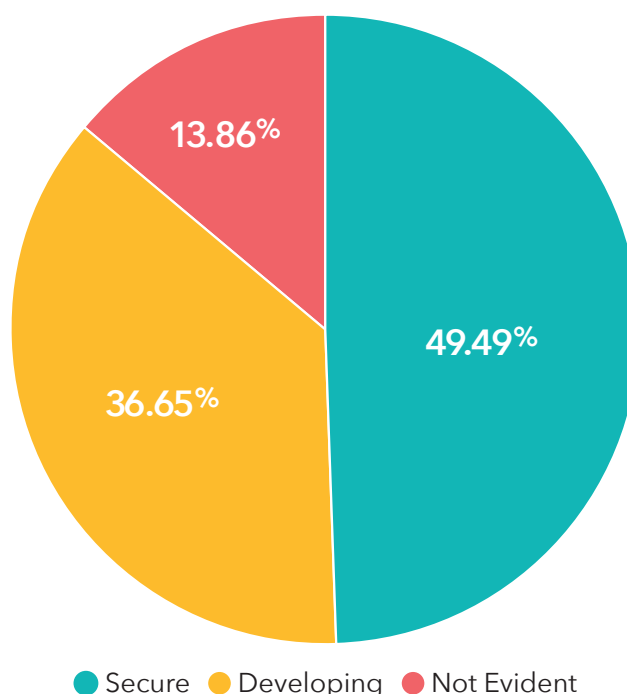
Speaking and listening and a broad genre of suitable reading materials scored in the mid-range of developing. Given the recent report by Speech and Language UK (September 2023) highlighted over 1.9 million children in the UK with a speaking difficulty. This is an area that needs to be considered further.

The strongest dimension in this section was 'celebration activities' for progress. Whilst this is to be applauded, the question that arises is, does this take away from extending learning? Observing the data across sections, in the impact section, promoting high aspirations and destination support scored significantly higher than pupil progress and suitable differentiated tasks for homework.

This begs the question, is there a lack of depth to responsive provision? The data would suggest this as a possibility. In which case, does the challenge rest in assessment, identification or provision?

Area 2: Reasonable Adjustments

Average Score: 1.36 (67.8%)

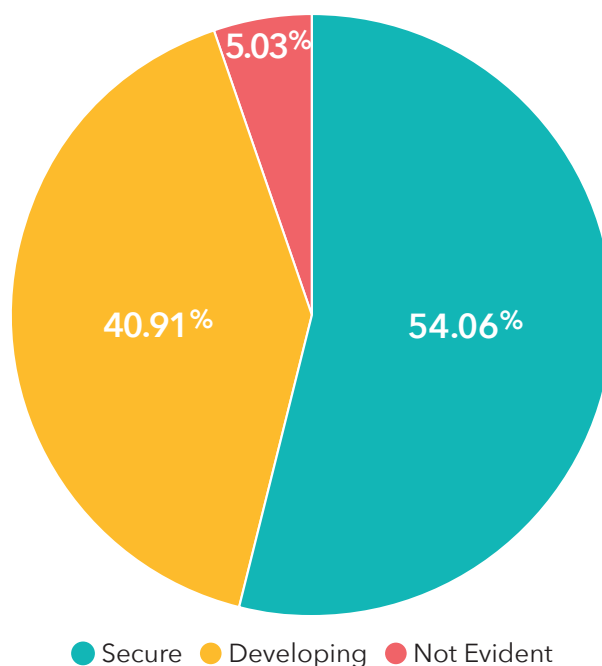


Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

The average was marginally lower than 'Quality of Provision for all', yet overall this had the highest margin falling in the 'not evident' data set. Marginally behind the lack of accessibility audit (64.2%) was lack of connectivity between subject curriculum and suitable multi-sensory resources. From the data it is not clear whether this relates to awareness of multi-sensory resources by subject leads, existence of resource lists or actual use in the classroom. Often the resources exist in settings, but are not widely used or staff members are not made aware. This is an area to consider when settings are reviewing their budgets. Staff training on The Equality Act 2010 was minimal (55.3%).

Area 3: Identification and Additional Provision

Average Score: 1.49 (74.5%)



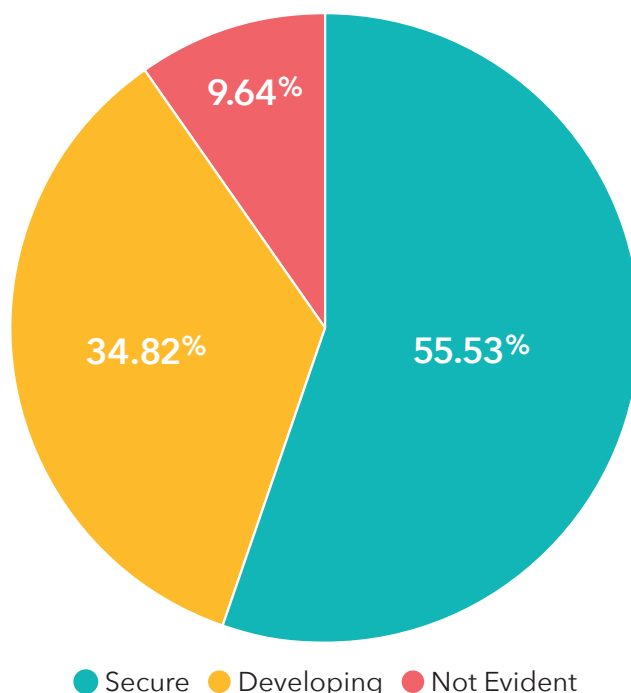
Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

The strongest element of this area was the maintenance of a register of needs (87.8%). Followed by a clear and transparent referral process across all four broad areas of need. However transparency of the referral timeline process to parents and carers was a significant area for development.

Whilst data management of needs was reported to be evident, an area of weakness is the use of live data. For example, intervention data,, impact data and the transference of learning from out-of-class interventions to in-class learning. It could be argued therefore, the tangible tickbox requirements are being met, however, connected live data to reflect processes, patterns and impact, (that underpins the system) is being neglected. As pointed out by the House of Lords in December 2022, lack of monitoring is prevalent at national level. Hence the spillage over in frontline delivery is a by-product of national policy and direction.

Area 4: Leadership and Team Working

Average Score: 1.46 (72.9%)

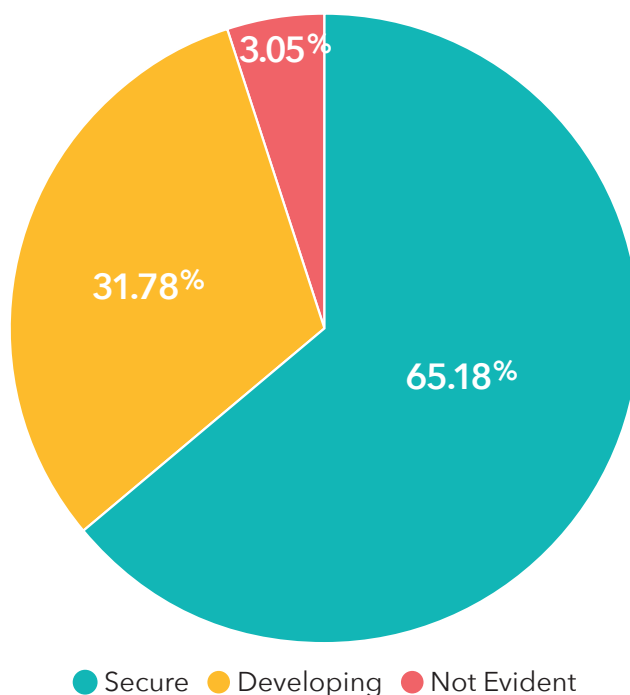


Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

Only 33.2% of setting annually train their staff on the fundamentals of the SEND Code of Practice 2015. In an area with high staff mobility or higher number of Early Career Teachers this could have year on year impact on the quality of provision for pupils. The data also profiled a strong emphasis on SEND being part of the setting evaluation and development planning (82.2%), however this related very much to the over emphasis of a SEND Policy in place (88.8%). The quality of SEND policies vary both in length and content and data from the Co-production section suggests wider stakeholders (including parents and carer) are not involved (40.1%).

Area 5: Co-production

Average Score: 1.62 (81.1%)

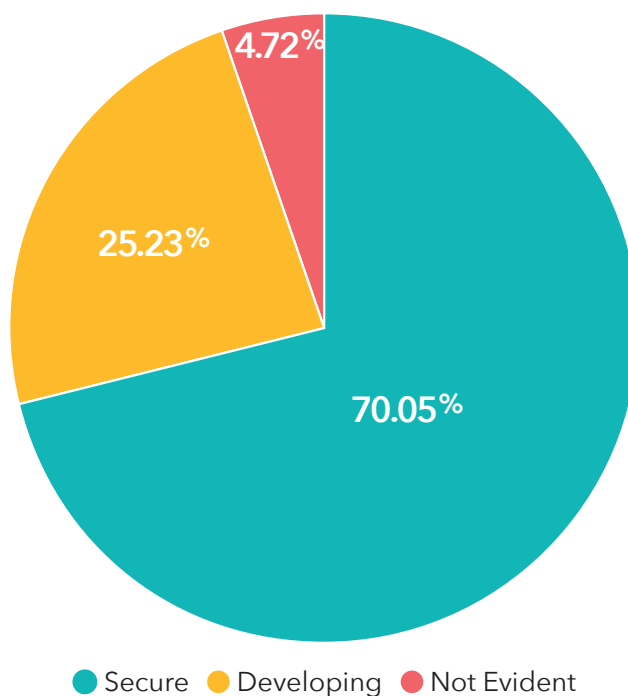


Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

This area scored the second highest secure percentage across all the settings. A dimension for development in this area would be the engagement of all stakeholders in constructing and developing the SEND Policy and SEN Information Report. This appears counter intuitive given that both these documents form the foundational aspects of systems and structure plus accountability at setting level. Therefore we can deduce co-production is limited to delivery process, not shaping local culture. In others words a firefighting system, rather than a growing system. This may indicate a need for the distinction nationally between what does responsive SEND provision look like compared to continuous fire fighting.

Area 6: External Stakeholders

Average Score: 1.65 (82.7%)



Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

Whilst this area also scored highly, the most surprising response was a healthy working relationship with the local authority (85.0%). Good relationships with external specialists and keeping parents informed was also presented as a strength (90.4% and 91.4% respectively).

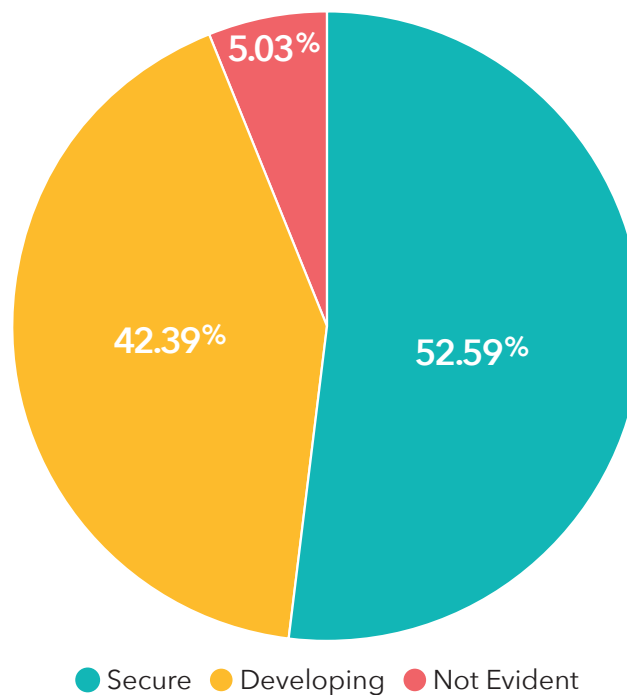
The healthy working relationships with local authorities would suggest a perception gap between what is reported in the press and the reality amongst practitioners. The onset of multi-academy trusts (MATs) has, without a doubt changed the landscape of influence for the local authorities.

The work with SEND pupils for whom English is an Additional Language (EAL) is predominantly delivered through the support of externals. Possibly highlighting an overall reliance on external support, as opposed to capacity building.

This has implications for the level of agency those leading on SEND are given or culturally experience when they have to drive whole setting initiatives.

Area 7: Impact

Average Score: 1.48 (73.8%)



Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

Whilst there was clear evidence of preparing pupils for the next stage (84.3%), what was noticeably lacking was the development of a wide range of core learning skills amongst SEND pupils (69.3%) and the matching of homework activities to meet needs (66%). This would suggest the system is still predominantly driven by objectives (what is done and provided), as opposed to outcomes (what difference it makes). This transition from objectives to outcomes was designed to be a significant shift in the 2014 SEND Reforms.

Summary and Conclusion

To our knowledge, this is the first time such a National SEND Audit has been undertaken that connects the micro with the macro to detect patterns locally, regionally and nationally.

The implications of this will be expanded upon in the fuller report with recommendations at setting, Multi-Academy Trust (MAT) and policy level. However, the comparative table below shows core strengths of the system to be co-production and engagement with external stakeholders. The reliance on external stakeholders, when connected with lack of Accessibility Audits (see Table 2) could indicate a lack of in-house skills in settings to support and drive inclusion.

Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

	Average score	Average percentage	Secure	Developing	Not evident
Quality of Provision for All	1.38	69.0%	45.28%	47.46%	7.26%
Reasonable Adjustments	1.36	67.8%	49.49%	36.65%	13.86%
Identification and Additional Provision	1.49	74.5%	54.06%	40.91%	5.03%
Leadership and Team Working	1.46	72.9%	55.53%	34.82%	9.64%
Co-production	1.62	81.18%	65.18%	31.78%	3.05%
External Stakeholders	1.65	82.7%	70.05%	25.23%	4.72%
Impact	1.48	73.8%	52.59%	42.39	5.03%

Table 1: Aggregate scores across the 7 sections

Scoring: Not Evident = 0 Developing = 1 Secure = 2

Statutory requirement statements in the SEND Audit 2023	
Pupil involvement in decision making	1.48
Accessibility Audit	1.04
Accessibility Plan	1.28
Reasonable adjustments log per class	1.32
Access to assistive technology	1.20
Access arrangements for examinations	1.69
Thorough and connected data management	1.51
SEN Support delivered and monitored effectively / use of the graduated Approach	1.56
SEND Governors fulfilling annual accountability	1.57
Acceptance and high aspirations	1.74
Wide stakeholder engagement in SEND Policy & SIR	1.20
Pupil voice is sought	1.56
Fulfilment of Section 19 Children & Families Act 2014	1.61
Core funding and resources effectively and efficiently deployed	1.62
Assets to support the four areas of need is clearly defined and monitored	1.28
Pupil progress across year groups and wide range of subjects is consistently strong through the promotion of independence	1.36

Table 2: Aggregate scores across key statements that were based on statutory duties.

Whilst acceptance of diverse needs and the promotion of high aspirations scored highly (86.8%), this is not matched in pupil progress (67.8%). The 19% differential requires further investigation.

Phase 1 of utilising the National SEND Audit has provided some interesting findings and insights connecting practice on the ground to legislation and national expectations. There are clear policy gaps, but also systemic and structural oversights.

Nearly ten years on from the enactment of the Children and Families Act 2014 and the piecemeal initiatives approach for change has failed to shift culture across the system. This provides strong evidence for a more joint-up thinking approach going forward. Suggestions will be made in the fuller report.

Envisioning for the future:

Imagine if every setting in the country undertook an audit like this on a termly basis, would this enable settings to monitor and track progress better?

The average time take to complete the National SEND Audit was 2 hours. So, it is possible to see this as an effective and efficient tool for linking practice and policy on a termly basis, at four levels: individual settings, multi academy trusts, regionally and nationally. Do get in touch with the team to find out what this might look like in practice.

References:

Brader, C. (2023) House of Lords: Children and Families Act 2014: Lords committee report <https://lordslibrary.parliament.uk/children-and-families-act-2014-lords-committee-report/>

DfE (2023) More support for children with special educational needs <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/more-support-for-children-with-special-educational-needs>

Speech and Language UK (2023) Listening to unheard children <https://speechandlanguage.org.uk/listening-to-unheard-children/>